

Policy Journal: Voter Suppression and Election Policy

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Introduction

For this journal I decided to track the debate over voter suppression, voting access, and election security in the United States during summer 2026. I originally thought this would mostly mean following one bill, the SAVE America Act, but it ended up being much broader than that. Congress was debating national voter ID and citizenship verification rules, President Trump was using executive action and public pressure, the Department of Justice was demanding voter information from states, and states were pushing back against some of those demands. Federal courts were also deciding how far the executive branch could go, while agencies like the Election Assistance Commission and Postal Service became involved too.

One thing that changed for me as I followed this issue was how I thought about the term “voter suppression.” I still think voter suppression is an important part of the debate, but I do not think every election security policy can automatically be called voter suppression without looking at what the policy actually does. Supporters argue that these policies are needed to prevent illegal voting and keep voter rolls accurate. Voting rights groups and many state officials argue that some of the same policies can make voting harder for eligible citizens or give the federal government too much control over elections. I ended up finding that disagreement over what the actual problem is almost as interesting as the policies themselves.

Throughout the journal, I connected what I was following to concepts and readings from class. Some of the ideas that ended up being especially useful were policy entrepreneurship, evidence-based policymaking, administrative burdens, federalism, implementation, state capacity, and the role of political institutions. Following one issue over several weeks made it easier to see how these concepts can overlap in an actual policy debate.

Entry 1 — Week of June 15–19, 2026

Recent Developments:

The biggest election policy story I was following this week actually started a few days earlier, on June 11. FBI agents searched the Cleveland office of the Ohio Organizing Collaborative, or OOC, a grassroots organization involved in voter registration and other social justice work. According to the Associated Press, agents seized documents and computer files and also went to the homes of people who had worked with the organization. A person familiar with the investigation said investigators were examining possible fraud violations, but the DOJ had not publicly explained the full reason for the investigation at that point (AP, 2026).

My first reaction was to see the search as a voter suppression effort. OOC leaders and several Democratic politicians did accuse the federal government of intimidation, but that does not necessarily mean that was the actual motive behind the investigation. I think there is an important difference between what happened and how different sides interpreted why it happened.

There was also a very different election development on June 15. The Election Assistance Commission announced a new professional certification program for election officials. The program requires participants to complete 30 training credits and is meant to improve the skills of state and local officials who actually administer elections (EAC, 2026).

Actors and Institutions:

The main actors included the FBI, DOJ, OOC, Ohio political officials, members of Congress, and the Election Assistance Commission. Rep. Shontel Brown, former Sen. Sherrod Brown, and other Democrats criticized the OOC search. Ohio Secretary of State Frank LaRose had also previously defended Ohio's cooperation with federal agencies on voter roll maintenance. I could not find evidence showing that this cooperation directly caused the OOC investigation, though, so I do not think it makes sense to treat those two things as directly connected.

Policy Concepts Applied:

One course reading that connects well to this week is Mintrom's discussion of policy entrepreneurs. Policy entrepreneurs try to draw attention to problems, build support around their interpretation of those problems, and push certain policy solutions. I could see that happening on both sides of the election debate. The Trump administration was already focused on voter fraud and election security, while OOC and voting rights

advocates were more focused on whether federal actions could discourage people from registering or participating (Mintrom, 2019).

Cairney's reading on evidence-based policymaking also fits here. One thing I took from that reading is that evidence does not just automatically lead policymakers to one obvious answer. Political actors can look at the same information and come away with very different ideas about what the problem actually is. That was happening with the OOC investigation. Supporters of stronger election enforcement could see it as evidence that possible fraud should be investigated, while critics saw the investigation as potentially intimidating voters and registration groups (Cairney, 2016).

Reflection:

What surprised me most was how quickly people decided what the investigation meant before the public knew much about the evidence behind it. I did the same thing at first. After reading more about it, I started thinking more about what effect a highly publicized federal investigation of a voter registration organization could have on people who might want to register or get involved.

Even if an investigation is legally justified, it could still make some people hesitant to participate. At the same time, the government obviously has a responsibility to investigate fraud if there is actual evidence of it. That makes the situation more complicated than just choosing between "fraud" and "suppression."

Entry 2 — Week of June 22–26, 2026

Recent Developments:

This week had a pretty strange connection between housing and election policy. The Senate approved the final version of the 21st Century ROAD to Housing Act on June 22 by an 85–5 vote, and the House passed it on June 23 by 358–32 (U.S. Senate, 2026; U.S. House of Representatives, 2026).

On June 24, Trump canceled a planned signing event and connected his decision not to sign the bill at that point to his demand for action on the SAVE America Act. The housing bill had passed by huge bipartisan margins, so it was interesting to see Trump use a mostly unrelated and much less partisan bill to put pressure on Congress over election policy (AP, 2026).

Another major development came on June 25. A federal court in Massachusetts blocked important parts of Trump’s March election executive order. The lawsuit was brought by states arguing that the federal government was interfering with state control over voter rolls and mail voting. The ruling stopped federal agencies from carrying out some of the challenged parts of the order in those states (Massachusetts Attorney General, 2026).

Actors and Institutions:

The main actors this week were Trump, the House, the Senate, supporters and opponents of the SAVE America Act, state attorneys general, and the federal courts. The Postal Service and DHS were involved too because Trump’s executive order directed federal agencies to take actions involving citizenship information and mail ballots.

Policy Concepts Applied:

The administrative burden reading from Moynihan, Herd, and Harvey connects pretty directly to the debate this week. They divide administrative burdens into learning costs, compliance costs, and psychological costs (Moynihan et al., 2015). Stronger citizenship verification or identification requirements might improve election security, but they can also require eligible voters to learn new rules, find documents, or complete extra steps before they can vote. Those costs are important when deciding whether an election policy is actually working as intended.

I also thought about the balance between government authority and individual liberty that has come up throughout the course. The administration argues that the federal government needs enough authority to protect election integrity, while states and voting rights groups argue that some of these requirements could interfere with state election systems or make

voting harder for eligible citizens. The court ruling showed that even when the goal of a policy might be election security, there are still limits on how the federal government can pursue it.

Reflection:

This week made the policy process seem a lot less organized than it looks in a textbook. A housing bill somehow became leverage in an election law fight while a federal court was deciding what the president could and could not do without Congress.

I usually think about separation of powers as each branch having its own job, but this showed me how much the branches are constantly reacting to each other. It also made me wonder whether connecting unrelated policies like this actually gives presidents more leverage or just creates more opposition.

Entry 3 — Week of June 29–July 3, 2026

Recent Developments:

The SAVE America Act was still having trouble in the Senate this week, but it was not simply sitting in committee. The Senate had already voted 51–48 on March 17 to proceed to the House message involving S. 1383, which had become the legislative vehicle for the SAVE America Act. The bigger issue was getting enough votes to overcome the Senate’s procedural barriers (U.S. Senate, 2026).

There was also a major Supreme Court decision on June 29 in *Watson v. Republican National Committee*. The Court held that federal Election Day laws do not require every absentee ballot to physically arrive at an election office by Election Day. This meant Mississippi could continue counting qualifying ballots that were postmarked by Election Day and arrived during the state’s five-day receipt period (Supreme Court, 2026).

Then, on July 2, California Attorney General Rob Bonta and a coalition of other state attorneys general opposed a proposed Postal Service rule involving mail voting. They argued that the rule would interfere with state election systems and improperly create a centralized federal voter information system (California DOJ, 2026).

Actors and Institutions:

The Supreme Court, state governments, Congress, USPS, and the executive branch were all involved this week. Something that stood out to me was how active the states were in all of this. They were not just waiting around for the federal government to decide what would happen. They were filing lawsuits, participating in federal rulemaking, and defending their own election policies.

Policy Concepts Applied:

Federalism fits this week especially well. We talked about federalism earlier in the course when looking at how responsibilities and resources are divided across levels of government. Elections create a similar issue because states administer most of the actual election process, but the federal government still has important authority over federal elections. The *Watson* decision showed that federal law does not always create one uniform national rule and that states can still have room to design their own election procedures.

This also reminded me of our housing discussions about state and local power. Michener’s discussion of state interference with local housing policy showed how decisions made by one level of government can limit what another level is able to do. Election policy is

obviously a different subject, but I saw a similar tension here. States were pushing back against federal actions that they believed interfered with their authority, including through lawsuits and the rulemaking process (Michener, 2023).

Reflection:

This week changed how I think about federalism. Before this class, I mostly pictured it as a chart with federal powers on one side and state powers on the other. Following election policy makes it seem much more like an ongoing argument over where the line is.

Congress can change election law, agencies can try to carry out federal policies, states can resist them, and courts can decide whether either side went too far. I can see how that protects against one national actor controlling everything, but it can also make elections more confusing when rules vary so much between states.

Entry 4 — Week of July 6–10, 2026

Recent Developments:

This was probably the most eventful week so far when it came to government agencies. On July 7, Assistant Attorney General Harmeet Dhillon, who headed DOJ's Civil Rights Division, sent letters to election officials warning about possible criminal liability if officials knowingly kept noncitizens on voter rolls or allowed noncitizens to receive and cast ballots. State officials were given five days to explain how they planned to comply with federal law. Some responded that their states already enforce citizenship requirements and criticized the tone and assumptions behind the letters (Reuters, 2026; CBS News, 2026).

Then, on July 9, Trump removed the two Democratic members of the Election Assistance Commission, Thomas Hicks and Benjamin Hovland. Republican commissioner Christy McCormick resigned. The other Republican commissioner, Donald Palmer, had already left the agency on April 30, so the EAC was left without commissioners (EAC, 2026).

The White House cited the Supreme Court's *Trump v. Slaughter* decision when defending Trump's removal authority. That does not mean the Supreme Court specifically ruled that Trump could remove these EAC commissioners, though. The agency itself also did not disappear. Career employees were still there, but not having commissioners limited the agency's ability to make major new decisions.

Actors and Institutions:

The main actors were DOJ's Civil Rights Division, Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche, Harmeet Dhillon, state election officials, Trump, the EAC commissioners, Congress, and the Supreme Court.

The EAC was especially interesting to me because Congress designed it to be bipartisan. It does not directly run elections, but it supports election administration through voting system testing, grants, standards, guidance, and other responsibilities.

Policy Concepts Applied:

Moynihan, Herd, and Harvey helped me think about the DOJ letters this week. They describe how interactions with government can create learning, compliance, and psychological costs. In this case, stricter enforcement around voter eligibility could create more requirements for states and potentially for individual voters. The goal might be keeping voter rolls accurate, but the reading made me think about the extra steps that can come with that goal and who actually has to deal with those costs (Moynihan et al., 2015).

I also connected this to some of the basic public policy concepts we covered at the beginning of the course. One thing that has become clearer to me is that passing laws is only part of policymaking. Government agencies still have to interpret and enforce those laws. DOJ already had authority to enforce federal election laws, but the administration could still change which issues it focused on and how aggressively it approached them. The EAC situation also showed how the way an agency is structured can affect what it is able to do when its leadership changes.

Reflection:

The EAC situation surprised me because I had barely heard of the agency before I started following this topic. Once I looked into what it actually does, it made more sense why its leadership could become such a big issue even though the EAC does not directly run elections.

It also made me realize how much of government happens through agencies that most people probably never think about. They can operate in the background for years and then suddenly end up in the middle of a major political fight. I am still not sure whether giving a president more control over agencies like this creates more democratic accountability or just makes election administration more partisan.

Entry 5 — Week of July 13–17, 2026

Recent Developments:

This week the election debate shifted more toward presidential messaging and DOJ leadership. On July 15, the Senate Judiciary Committee held Todd Blanche's hearing on his nomination to become Attorney General. Blanche was already serving as Acting Attorney General, so the hearing mattered because DOJ had become one of the main institutions involved in Trump's election agenda (Senate Judiciary Committee, 2026).

Then, on July 16, Trump gave a nationally televised address about election security. The next day, the White House released more material arguing that newly declassified information showed foreign threats to election infrastructure and voter information. Trump and Vice President JD Vance connected those claims to the SAVE America Act (White House, 2026).

I do think there is a difference between saying the White House made these claims and saying that every part of them had been independently proven. For this journal, the speech is more useful for looking at how the administration was framing the election security issue and trying to get more attention on it.

Actors and Institutions:

The main actors were Trump, the White House, Acting Attorney General Blanche, the Senate Judiciary Committee, congressional supporters of the SAVE America Act, intelligence agencies, and voting rights groups. Federal courts were still involved too because parts of Trump's executive election agenda were already being challenged.

Policy Concepts Applied:

Mintrom's idea of policy entrepreneurship fits Trump's approach this week pretty well. A policy entrepreneur does more than just support a particular proposal. They also try to build attention around a problem and convince other people that their preferred policy is the right response. Trump already had a solution he supported in the SAVE America Act, so the election security speech gave him another opportunity to argue that the problem was serious enough for Congress to act (Mintrom, 2019).

Cairney's discussion of evidence-based policymaking also made me think more carefully about the White House releasing intelligence information alongside the speech. Evidence matters in policymaking, but it still has to be interpreted and presented by political actors. The administration emphasized information that supported its argument about election security, while critics questioned whether that evidence supported all of the conclusions

Trump was drawing from it. That does not mean the evidence was irrelevant. It shows why it is important to separate the evidence itself from the policy argument being built around it (Cairney, 2016).

Reflection:

This week made me more skeptical about taking political speeches as straightforward explanations of policy problems. A president can use real information but still choose which parts to emphasize and when to release it.

What interested me more was why this information was being emphasized at this particular point. Trump kept connecting different election developments back to the SAVE America Act. It made me wonder whether repeatedly calling something urgent eventually becomes less effective if Congress keeps not acting on it.

Entry 6 — Week of July 20–24, 2026

Recent Developments:

This week there was an actual administrative failure that quickly became part of the national election debate. On July 21, New Jersey Gov. Mikie Sherrill announced that a software error in the state Motor Vehicle Commission system had resulted in around 6,600 people who indicated that they were not U.S. citizens being registered to vote between June 2023 and June 2024. The system processed their voter registrations even though they had answered “no” when asked whether they were U.S. citizens (New Jersey Governor’s Office, 2026).

Sherrill ordered an investigation and corrections to the voter rolls. The state’s preliminary review found that fewer than 400 people who were newly registered because of the error had voted.

The White House quickly used the incident to argue for passage of the SAVE America Act (White House, 2026). There is an important difference, though, between what New Jersey confirmed and how the White House described the situation. The state confirmed a serious software problem, but the governor’s announcement did not establish that all 6,600 people were still noncitizens at every relevant later date or that every ballot cast by someone affected by the error was illegal.

There was also movement in the court fight over Trump’s mail voting executive order. Voting rights organizations renewed their request for an injunction, and on July 22 a federal court allowed important parts of their challenge to continue (League of Women Voters, 2026).

Actors and Institutions:

The actors included Sherrill, the New Jersey MVC, state election officials, the software vendor, affected residents, the White House, Congress, federal courts, and voting rights organizations.

New Jersey ended up in an interesting position because the state had to deal with a real mistake in its own system while also watching that mistake become part of the national debate over election security.

Policy Concepts Applied:

The New Jersey situation made me think about something we have talked about throughout the course, which is the difference between creating a policy and actually carrying it out. New Jersey already had rules saying noncitizens could not register to vote, but those rules

still depended on software, employees, databases, and other systems working correctly. In this case, the policy itself was clear but there was still a failure in how it was administered.

The reading from Moynihan, Herd, and Harvey also matters when thinking about what should happen next. Adding more verification could help prevent certain mistakes, but it could also create more learning and compliance costs for eligible voters. That does not automatically mean stronger verification is bad policy. It means policymakers have to think about both accuracy and how difficult the process becomes for people who are legally allowed to vote (Moynihan et al., 2015).

Reflection:

This probably changed my thinking about the issue more than any other week because it made it harder to see the debate as completely one-sided. Administrative mistakes clearly can happen, and individual cases of illegal voting can happen too. Election security is not just an imaginary issue.

For me, the harder question is how large the problem actually is and what kind of response makes sense. Does one major software failure mean the country needs a nationwide proof-of-citizenship requirement, or does it mostly mean that New Jersey needed to fix this particular system? I do not think this incident alone really answers that.

Entry 7 — Week of July 27–31, 2026

Recent Developments:

By the last week of July, the SAVE America Act had turned into a pretty direct fight between Trump's agenda and Senate procedure. On July 27, Trump demanded that Senate Majority Leader John Thune keep senators in Washington instead of starting their August break until they passed the SAVE America Act. Trump was also continuing to push Republicans to eliminate the legislative filibuster or find another way around it (AP, 2026).

Republicans controlled the Senate 53–47, but most legislation still effectively needed 60 votes to overcome a filibuster. Thune said Republicans did not have enough votes to pass the legislation or enough support to change the Senate rules.

That same day, the administration took another part of the election fight to the Supreme Court. In *Trump v. California*, the federal government asked the Court to temporarily block lower-court restrictions on Trump's election executive order while the case continued. The application was filed July 27, with responses due August 3 (Supreme Court, 2026).

There was another development on July 30 when DOJ announced that a lawful permanent resident had pleaded guilty in Texas to illegally voting and falsely claiming U.S. citizenship (DOJ, 2026). This was an actual documented case of illegal noncitizen voting. At the same time, one case shows that something can happen, not necessarily how often it happens across the entire country.

Actors and Institutions:

The major actors were Trump, Thune, Republican and Democratic senators, DOJ, the Supreme Court, state governments challenging Trump's executive order, and federal prosecutors.

At this point, Congress and the courts were basically two different places where the same larger election policy fight was playing out.

Policy Concepts Applied:

This week connected almost directly to our voting unit. One of the readings was Trump's executive order on preserving and protecting the integrity of American elections, but we also had readings presenting different views about voter suppression and federal voting policy (Trump, 2025). What I took from putting those readings together is that a lot of this debate comes down to how the problem is defined. One side sees stronger federal requirements as protecting election integrity, while the other worries about how those requirements affect access to voting and state control over elections.

Grumbach's reading on states as "laboratories of democratic backsliding" also fits the larger state-versus-federal conflict I had been following. States have a lot of authority over election administration, which means important democratic rules can vary depending on where someone lives. At the same time, federal intervention meant to create more consistency can create its own concerns about who should control elections. The fights between states and the administration showed how election rules themselves can become part of the political conflict rather than just neutral rules everyone agrees on (Grumbach, 2022).

Reflection:

Something I took away from this week is that saying one party "controls Washington" is pretty misleading. Republicans controlled the presidency and Senate, but Senate rules, courts, federalism, and administrative authority could still get in the way of what the administration wanted.

Venue shopping also finally clicked for me after seeing the same issue move from Congress to executive action and then into the courts. I understand why these checks exist, but it also makes me wonder if congressional gridlock is one reason so many major political questions end up being decided through executive orders and court cases instead.

Entry 8 — Week of August 3–7, 2026

Recent Developments:

By the first week of August, it seemed like the biggest story was becoming the limits the administration was running into. The Supreme Court case *Trump v. California* was still moving forward after the administration asked the Court to block lower-court restrictions on Trump's election executive order. There was also a larger pattern developing in DOJ's voter roll lawsuits. On August 7, Reuters reported that the Trump administration had lost 21 consecutive federal district court cases in its effort to force states to turn over detailed voter registration information. DOJ had appealed 16 of those losses (Reuters, 2026).

DOJ argued that federal election and civil rights laws gave it the authority to obtain information it needed to evaluate how states were maintaining their voter rolls. States and federal judges repeatedly disagreed with how broadly DOJ was interpreting that authority.

The Senate also reached the end of its pre-recess period without passing the SAVE America Act. Early on August 8, right after the week covered by this entry, senators left Washington without passing it (AP, 2026). Trump had definitely succeeded in keeping the bill in the national conversation, but keeping something on the agenda is obviously different from actually getting it passed.

Actors and Institutions:

By this point, there were a lot of actors involved: DOJ, state attorneys general, election officials, federal district courts, appellate courts, the Supreme Court, Trump, Thune, Senate Republicans and Democrats, DHS, and state and local election administrators.

What stood out to me was just how many different institutions had become involved by the end. This was no longer just Trump trying to get an election bill through Congress. The same policy fight was happening across different levels and branches of government.

Policy Concepts Applied:

By the end of the journal, implementation and state capacity stood out to me more than they did at the beginning. Rahman's reading helped me think about government capacity as more than just whether the government has legal authority to do something. Government also needs the employees, information, institutions, and systems necessary to actually carry a policy out. The New Jersey software failure was one example of this, while DOJ's problems obtaining state voter information showed another type of capacity problem (Rahman, 2024).

Moe's focus on political institutions also helps explain why this debate became so complicated. Congress, DOJ, the president, state governments, election agencies, and federal courts all had different powers and responsibilities. Even when the administration had a clear policy goal, it still had to work through institutions that could limit or challenge what it wanted to do. That probably ended up being one of the biggest things I learned from following this issue: writing a policy or announcing a goal is only one part of policymaking. Whether the government can actually implement it depends on the institutions and administrative systems involved (Moe, 1990).

Reflection:

At the beginning of this journal, I thought the main thing I would be following was whether the SAVE America Act passed. By the end, that seems like only one part of the story. I became more interested in who actually controls election policy when authority is divided between Congress, the president, federal agencies, states, local election officials, and courts. After following this for the summer, I do not think any one of them completely does.

I also ended up with a more complicated view of voter suppression and election integrity than I had when I started. There are real administrative mistakes and real individual cases of illegal voting, so I do not think election security can just be dismissed as a fake issue. At the same time, showing that a problem exists does not automatically mean that every proposed restriction is necessary or that it is the best solution.

The biggest thing I learned is probably that policymaking is less about one institution simply "winning" than I expected. Trump could keep an issue on the agenda but could not make senators give him 60 votes. DOJ could file lawsuits, but judges could reject its arguments. States could fight federal demands while still having to fix problems in their own election systems. Courts could block executive actions, but the administration could appeal those decisions.

Following the same issue for the whole summer made a lot of the concepts from class easier for me to understand. Instead of thinking about federalism, administrative burdens, implementation, state capacity, and political institutions as separate ideas, I got to see how several of them can be happening at the same time in one policy debate.

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